has his home on Mount Meru, the primordial mountain at the centre of the cosmos. In the human world its geographical location shifts from place to place and it looms particularly large in the second of the great epics of Hinduism, the *Ramayana*.

Laid out in twenty-four thousand couplets, 'Rama's journey' is built around the person of the god-king Rama and his epic struggle with Ravana, the demon king of Lanka. I have been assured that Prince Rama himself was born on 4 December 7323 BCE. Even so, the widespread consensus among modern scholars is that his story was composed in two phases, with the book's five middle sections probably assembled no earlier than the fourth century BCE and the first and last sections added in about the first century BCE. Central to the story is Rama's portrayal as an incarnation of Lord Vishnu, who begins his spectacular rise to prominence at this same time. What is also apparent from the story is that the author or authors of the *Ramayana* were very much at home with the geography of Bharat north of the Narmada, but knew little about what lay beyond, even if its main rivers had been given names.

For many Hindus, there is only one version of Rama's journey and that is Valmiki's *Ramayana*, written in Sanskrit, although many Tamil-speakers would be quick to argue that their version – Kamban's *Ramayanam*, also known as *Ramavataram* – is far superior, being the work of a thirteenth-century court poet from Thanjavur, and first read out by him in the precincts of the vast Sri Ranganathaswamy Vishnu temple on the outskirts of Trichy.[5] This makes the point that there are in fact several hundred extant versions and variations of the tale. Not only does every region in India have its own form of the *Ramayana* story but so, too, do a number of Hindu sects, each with its own take.[6] Even the Buddhists and the Jains have their versions, in which no deities are involved and no mention is